Begin with your own life

Fuller living does not have to mean a busier calendar or a more impressive routine. It can mean more room for a familiar interest, a relationship, a quiet moment, or a question you have been putting off.

Use this guide in any order. Skip a prompt, speak your answers instead of writing them, or work through a page with someone you trust. There is no score, streak, or required pace.

This is a reflection and planning guide, not a cognitive assessment or an individualized health plan.

What would I like a little more room for?

What am I already doing that I want to keep?

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Put brain health in perspective

Cognitive health includes the ability to think, learn, and remember. The National Institute on Aging discusses physical health, sleep, physical activity, social connection, and meaningful activities as relevant to cognitive health. These are areas for conversation and everyday care—not a promise that a particular routine prevents dementia.

Use the questions below to prepare a conversation with a health professional. Do not change prescribed medicines based on this guide.

This guide does not recommend supplements, treatment, or a specific exercise program.

Is there a concern about sleep, memory, mood, hearing, vision, or medication effects I want to discuss?

What question would help me make an informed decision?

National Institute on Aging — Cognitive Health and Older Adults
https://www.nia.nih.gov/health/brain-health/cognitive-health-and-older-adults

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Notice the shape of your day

Begin with what a typical day actually looks like, rather than what you think it should look like. Think about meals, work, rest, travel, interests, and time with other people.

Look for one moment where a small adjustment might create room for something you value. The aim is not to fill every gap. Rest and unstructured time can belong in your plan, too.

A part of my day that already works for me:

A part of my day I would like to make easier:

Something I can simplify, share, postpone, or leave out:

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Make connection possible

Connection can take different forms: a call, a shared meal, listening to music together, a short visit, or being comfortably in the same room. Choose a form that fits the relationship, your preferences, and what is possible right now.

An invitation can be specific without becoming a demand: “Would you like to have tea together this week?” Leave room for the other person to suggest something different or decline.

Someone I would enjoy connecting with:

A simple invitation I could offer:

What would make it easier for both of us?

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Keep interests in the picture

An interest does not need to be productive to deserve space. Think about music, stories, cooking, nature, making something, spirituality, learning, humor, or a place you enjoy.

An activity can be adapted to your energy, access, or preferences. Listening can count as participation. Watching, choosing, sharing an opinion, and simply enjoying something together can matter, too.

Something I enjoy or feel curious about:

A version that would fit my life this week:

Something I would like to try, without pressure to become good at it:

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Choose one manageable step

Choose one thing, not a complete overhaul. Make it specific enough that you can picture doing it. A useful plan also has room for things not going as expected.

Example: “On Wednesday afternoon, I will ask a friend whether they would like a short phone call. If Wednesday becomes difficult, I will suggest the weekend.” This is an example of planning, not a prescription.

My one step:

When or where I will try it:

What might get in the way—and a gentler alternative:

Who or what could help:

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Prepare a useful conversation

Some questions belong with a health professional rather than in a self-guided plan. Write your concern in ordinary language and include what matters to you.

A starting sentence might be: “I have noticed a change, and I would like to understand it.” You do not need to arrive with a diagnosis. Keep your own observations separate from what someone else has noticed.

For memory or thinking concerns, talk with a health professional. For sudden possible stroke symptoms, call 911 rather than waiting for an appointment.

What I would like to discuss:

An example or date I want to remember:

The question I most want answered:

National Institute on Aging — Memory Problems, Forgetfulness, and Aging
https://www.nia.nih.gov/health/memory-loss-and-forgetfulness/memory-problems-forgetfulness-and-aging
Centers for Disease Control and Prevention — Signs and Symptoms of Stroke
https://www.cdc.gov/stroke/signs-symptoms/index.html

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Reflect, then make room again

After you have tried your step, pause without giving yourself a grade. What felt meaningful? What was inconvenient or too demanding? What would you change?

You can repeat a useful step, make it smaller, choose something different, or decide that this is not the right time. The point is to build a plan around your life—not judge your life against a plan.

The companion “One Meaningful Step” worksheet collects these prompts on a single printable page. Keep completed pages private and share only what you choose.

What felt worthwhile?

What would I keep, simplify, or change?

My next step—or what I am choosing to set aside:

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